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Democrats in House allege fraud acts by Freedom 250

Report claims consultants tricked financial donors to organization tied to Trump

By Michael Biesecker
and Josh Boak
ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON — Consultants tied to President Donald Trump may have engaged in financial fraud, tricking donors who wanted to support the nation's bipartisan 250th anniversary organizer into sending their money instead to a rival group set up by his administration, according to a report released Thursday by House Democrats.

The report draws in part on interviews by Democratic staffers of the House Committee on Natural Resources. Those interviews suggest that donors seeking to celebrate America fell for a bait-and-switch that, if true, could have violated various criminal statutes.

Donors who were intending to contribute funds to America250, a bipartisan committee created by Congress, were instead given the banking and routing numbers for a different but similarly named group, Freedom 250 — a ruse the Democratic report says could constitute wire fraud.

The key difference was that Freedom 250 was set up under the auspices of Trump's Republican administration to be "a vehicle for a Christian nationalist, partisan, and Trump-centered vision of American identity," according to the report.

Freedom 250, which has denied the report's claims, has focused on staging big splashy events largely held in Washington, such as the UFC cage fight at the White House on Trump's 80th birthday, the Great American State Fair on the National Mall and the upcoming Fourth of July celebration featuring a Trump speech and a fireworks extravaganza the president is touting as the "show of a lifetime."

Freedom 250 spokesperson Danielle Alvarez dismissed the report as "categorically false" and a "partisan smear from politicians

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Paramedics transport a person from the scene where seven people were shot, two fatally, near the 5100 block of South Wood Street in Chicago's New City neighborhood in the early hours of June 5. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Burst of gun violence hits Back of the Yards

Wave of shootings highlights long-term questions in a city trying to build on historic progress

By Caroline Kubzansky
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The gunshot wound on Thomas Torres' right arm is three or four inches long and still healing.

It's been about a month since Torres and a friend were shot as they drove down South Throop Street to a morning appointment in the Back of the Yards area. Torres was shot in the arm, and his friend was shot in the back. A few hundred feet in front of them, Pedro Ramirez, a Tilden High School junior on his way to school, was killed.

Torres, 55, does not believe he or his companion were the targets of the shooting that morning. Nor does he think the gunfire was meant for Ramirez. But that's about where his certainty runs out. In the past month, he's asked himself one question over and over: "What person wakes up at 7:30 a.m. and shoots a 17-year-old little guy and two old men?"

Torres, his companion and Ramirez were three of the people wounded or killed in 60 shootings around the Deering District (9th) since the start of the year. The district, and particularly the

Back of the Yards area, is enduring a burst of gun violence after a historic dip last year.

CPD data shows that across Chicago, shootings and homicides are still much lower, year-to-date, than they were in 2022 as the city emerged from the pandemic. And homicides in most of the city are virtually flat or decreasing sharply compared to the same period last year.

A swath of the city's South Side, and the Deering District in particular, is the exception. The district, which stretches from Chinatown, Bridgeport and Canaryville across

the Back of the Yards and McKinley Park to Gage Park, has so far tallied a 183% increase in homicides compared to the same period in 2025. The CPD area that covers Deering, known as Area 1, has seen a 68% increase in homicides, data shows.

That means two things. First, it means the uptick in gun violence Chicago has seen in 2026 is driven in large part by shootings in a relatively small portion of the city. And it means that the people who live in those neighborhoods — many of

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Morgan McLuckie, executive director of The Orange Tent Project, gives water to Shirley Head while passing out water to people living in an encampment under an Interstate 90 viaduct on the Lower West Side on Thursday. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Critics: City's cooling network 'inadequate'

Advocates call for more 24/7 relief, especially for homeless, those with no AC

By Adriana Pérez
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

In 1995, a deadly heat wave hit Chicago, killing over 700 people and redefining the city's emergency response.

But the threat of heat-related death still looms as recent years — and days — have shown, and especially as climate change intensifies and lengthens hot stretches.

Changes to city policies over the past three decades have not been nearly enough to protect residents,

critics say.

In 2022, three women died in a Rogers Park apartment building inside their units, which were so hot their families described conditions as "oven-like." Their deaths spurred laws at the state and city levels to tighten cooling standards.

In 2024, dozens of City Council members penned a letter asking Mayor Brandon Johnson and Chief Homelessness Officer Sindy Soto to call a workinggroup and reexamine remaining shortcomings in the city's approach

to extreme weather, specifically cold and heat. Talks have recently stalled.

A Tribune analysis last year found that most city locations advertised as cooling centers were either splash pads or closed most or part of the time during a heat wave that took place over the Juneteenth holiday weekend, and only police stations remained open overnight. During this week's heat wave, only five locations in

See **COOLING** on Page A2

Boutros makes appearance as grand jury scandal grows

US attorney defiantly claims victory in an anti-violence operation

By Madeline Buckley
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Embattled U.S. Attorney Andrew Boutros on Thursday made one of his first local public appearances since his office dropped charges in the "Broadview Six" case amid alleged grand jury improprieties, defiantly claiming victory in an anti-violence operation, saying that "no reckless reporting can take away from our results."

Amid an unprecedented scandal for Chicago's U.S. attorney's office, Boutros was joined by the director of the U.S. Bureau of Alcohol, Tobacco, Firearms, and Explosives and other law enforcement officials to announce the results of an initiative he convened to target

the "worst of the worst" in Chicago and Rockford, even as the Broadview Six fallout continues to mire his office in turmoil.

"Since then, I have worked day and night, literally, and weekends and holidays, literally, to keep the citizens of the Northern District of Illinois safe," Boutros said.

Though the news conference appeared designed to showcase a recent win for the office amid increasing scrutiny, Boutros was still asked about the Broadview Six case, despite telling reporters he hoped the questions would remain on topic and criticizing the media coverage the matter has received.

"I will be addressing a lot of that stuff in a lot more detail," Boutros said of the case, calling himself the "most accessible U.S. attorney probably ever."

Standing in front of a screen with rotating photos of mug shots,

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INSIDE

A rare occurrence for two franchises

This Fourth of July holiday weekend, we'll be celebrating a season unlike any other in recent memory. Despite obstacles galore, both the Cubs and White Sox are viable contenders. **Paul Sullivan in Sports**



Basking in 'power and talent'

Twenty-five seasons in, with more to come, Christopher Bell has built the Grant Park Chorus into Chicago's finest. **Arts & Entertainment**

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